

ANALYTICS

SHOPIFY + GA4 GUIDE

STOP FLYING BLIND

The Complete GA4 + Shopify Analytics
Setup Guide for Small Business

GA4

SEARCH CONSOLE

GOOGLE ADS

SHOPIFY

Your data at a glance — when it's set up properly.



10-Step GA4 Checklist

5 Essential Reports

4 Free Tools

Weekly Analytics Ritual

TABLE OF CONTENTS

What's Inside

Section 1 Why Your Analytics Are Probably Lying to You*the most common breakdowns***Section 2** The Analytics Stack That Actually Works*four free tools, properly connected***Part 1** GA4 Setup Checklist — 10 Steps*work through every one***– Key Events to Track***and which ones don't matter***– Shopify + GA4 Connection***step-by-step, including checkout tracking***Part 2** The 5 Reports Every Shopify Owner Needs*revenue by channel, conversion rate, more***Part 3** Your Weekly Analytics Ritual*10 minutes every Monday***Part 4** Google Ads + Search Console Integration*close the attribution loop***– Reading the Numbers***benchmarks, green flags, red flags***– Automating Your Reporting***set it and forget it***– Common Tracking Mistakes***and how to fix them***Bonus** Analytics Audit Checklist + Next Steps*your path to clean data*

01

Why Your Analytics Are Probably Lying

Most Shopify store analytics are broken — and the numbers look plausible enough that you never question them. You make decisions based on those numbers. You spend money based on those numbers. And then you wonder why your marketing feels like it's not working.

The Four Most Common Ways Your Data Is Already Wrong

1. You Installed GA4 But Didn't Configure It

Installing the tracking code gets you some data — but without proper configuration, you're missing purchase events (the most important thing), accurate channel attribution, internal traffic exclusions,

2. Your Shopify and GA4 Aren't Talking Properly

Shopify has its own analytics. GA4 has its analytics. They should agree — they almost never do. Causes include checkout subdomain breaks, payment gateway redirects (Afterpay, Zip, PayPal) that lose

3. You're Looking at Vanity Metrics

Sessions. Pageviews. Bounce rate. These feel useful — but can you draw a direct line from any of them to revenue? The metrics that matter: revenue by channel, conversion rate by source, average order value,

4. You're Missing Attribution Windows

Someone clicks your Instagram post, browses but doesn't buy. Three days later they Google your brand name and buy. In most default GA4 setups, Google/organic gets full credit. The Instagram post that

The Analytics Stack That Actually Works

Four free tools. Properly connected.

TOOL	WHAT IT DOES	COST
Google Analytics 4	Tracks user behaviour, conversions, and revenue by channel	Free
Google Search Console	Shows search rankings, clicks, impressions, and indexing status	Free
Google Ads	Paid traffic management and conversion tracking	Ad spend
Shopify Analytics	Order and revenue reporting — your source of truth for revenue fig...	Included
Google Tag Manager	Manages all tracking tags from one place (optional but recommen...	Free

Shopify Analytics — Your Revenue Source of Truth

When there's a discrepancy between Shopify and GA4, trust Shopify for revenue figures. GA4 can miss transactions due to ad blockers, slow page loads, or tracking gaps. Shopify can't miss an order because an order is what generates money.

What "Fixed" Looks Like

- Where did my revenue come from this month?
- What's my cost per new customer, by channel?
- Which products have the best (and worst) conversion rates?
- Where are people abandoning their carts?
- Are my Google Ads profitable?
- What percentage of my orders are from returning customers?
- What's changed since last month, and why?

GA4 Setup Checklist

10 Steps — Work through every one, even if you think yours is already set up.

1

Create or Access Your GA4 Property

Go to analytics.google.com — sign in with your business Google account. Click Admin → verify you're in the right Account and Property. If no GA4 property exists: Create Property → set name, timezone (Australia/Sydney), currency (AUD). Select business type (Shopping or Retail).

2

Connect Shopify to GA4

In Shopify Admin → Online Store → Preferences → paste your Measurement ID (G-XXXXXXX). Alternatively use Google & YouTube Sales Channel from the Shopify App Store — it handles enhanced ecommerce events automatically. Verify: check GA4 Realtime while browsing your store.

3

Enable Enhanced Measurement

GA4 Admin → Data Streams → select your stream → Enhanced Measurement toggle ON. This enables automatic tracking of scrolls, outbound clicks, site searches, video engagement, and file downloads without additional code.

4

Configure Purchase Event

This is the most important step. Verify purchase events are firing: GA4 → Reports → Realtime → Events. Place a test order and confirm "purchase" event appears with correct revenue value.

5

Exclude Internal Traffic

GA4 Admin → Data Streams → Configure Tag Settings → Define Internal Traffic. Add your office IP address(es). Then create a filter: Admin → Data Filters → Create Filter → Internal Traffic → Exclude.

6

Set Up Google Search Console Connection

GA4 Admin → Search Console Links → Link. This connects organic search data directly to GA4, enabling the Landing Pages report and organic query data.

7

Link Google Ads

GA4 Admin → Google Ads Links → Link. This enables auto-tagging and imports GA4 conversions into Google Ads for bidding. Critical for accurate ROAS measurement.

8

Create Audiences

GA4 Admin → Audiences → New Audience. Create: All Purchasers (last 30 days), Cart Abandoners (added to cart, did not purchase), High-Value Visitors (viewed 5+ products). These feed Google Ads remarketing.

9

Set Up Custom Reports

GA4 → Explore → + New Exploration. Build a revenue by channel report: dimensions = Session default channel group; metrics = Transactions, Revenue, Conversion Rate. Save this — you'll use it weekly.

10

Verify with Shopify Analytics

Compare GA4 revenue vs Shopify revenue for the last 30 days. Discrepancy under 5%: acceptable. 5–15%: investigate checkout tracking. Over 15%: something is fundamentally broken — revisit Steps 2 and 4.

Key Events to Track

And which ones don't actually matter.

Events that directly connect to revenue:

purchase The most important event. Revenue value, transaction ID, items.

add_to_cart Indicates purchase intent. Track cart abandonment from this.

begin_checkout Measures how far users progress through the checkout funnel.

view_item Product page engagement. Useful for product-level conversion rates.

search What are visitors looking for? Often reveals product gaps.

generate_lead Form submissions, quote requests, contact enquiries.

Events You Can Ignore

Events you don't need to worry about: `page_view` (tracked automatically), `scroll` (tracked automatically), `click` (tracked automatically via enhanced measurement). Don't add custom events for things GA4 already tracks.

The 5 Reports Every Shopify Owner Needs

Bookmark these. Check them every week.

Report 1 Revenue by Channel

Where: GA4 → Acquisition → Traffic Acquisition

What you're looking for: Which channels are actually driving revenue (not just traffic). Organic Search, Paid Search, Email, Social — each should have a story. If a channel has high traffic but zero revenue, it's either broken tracking or irrelevant traffic.

Report 2 Product Conversion Rates

Where: GA4 → Monetisation → Ecommerce Purchases

What you're looking for: Which products convert visitors to buyers. A product viewed 500 times with 2 purchases has a 0.4% rate — far below the 2–4% average. That's a pricing, photography, or description problem.

Report 3 Checkout Funnel

Where: GA4 → Monetisation → Checkout Journey

What you're looking for: Where people drop off. High drop at shipping? Your shipping costs are killing conversions. High drop at payment? Trust issues or payment method gaps.

Report 4 New vs Returning Customers

Where: Shopify Analytics → Customers → Returning Customers

What you're looking for: Repeat purchase rate. Healthy ecommerce sits at 25–40% returning. Under 15% means you're on an acquisition treadmill — every sale requires new ad spend.

Report 5 Channel CAC (Customer Acquisition Cost)

Build this in a Google Sheet: $\text{Ad spend per channel} \div \text{New customers from that channel} = \text{CAC}$.

Compare to your average order value and lifetime value. If $\text{CAC} > \text{AOV}$, you're losing money acquiring customers.

Your Weekly Analytics Ritual

10 minutes. Every Monday. Non-negotiable.

Why a Ritual Matters

The biggest mistake SME owners make with analytics is checking them randomly when something feels wrong. By then you've lost days or weeks of data that could have informed better decisions. Build the habit first — the insights follow.

1 min

Open your Shopify dashboard

Check last week's revenue vs the same week last year. Is it up or down? By how much?

2 min

Check GA4 Acquisition report

Which channel drove the most revenue? Any channel behaving unusually? A spike in Direct often means a campaign is mislabelled or UTMs are broken.

2 min

Review your conversion rate

Did it change? If it dropped, check the checkout funnel. If a payment gateway had an issue, you'll see it here before your bank statement does.

2 min

Check your top 5 products

Any surprise performers? Any that fell off a cliff? Changes in individual product conversion often signal a competitor move or a stock issue.

2 min

Google Ads (if running)

ROAS above your target threshold? Any campaigns going rogue? One minute to flag anything that needs a closer look today.

1 min

Note one thing to investigate

Write one question to dig into this week. "Why did organic drop 20%?" is better than ignoring it for a month.

Google Ads + Search Console Integration

Close the attribution loop.

Search Console: What It Tells You

- Which Google search queries are driving clicks to your site
- Your average position for important keywords
- Which pages are appearing in search results (and which aren't)
- Click-through rate — are your titles and descriptions compelling enough?
- Indexing issues — pages Google can't see won't rank

Google Ads: The Critical Settings

Enable auto-tagging

Google Ads → Settings → Auto-tagging → ON. This passes gclid parameters that allow GA4 to attribute conversions back to specific campaigns, ad groups, and keywords.

Import GA4 conversions into Google Ads

GA4 → Admin → Google Ads Links → select account → import conversion events. Import "purchase" as your primary conversion. This enables Smart Bidding to optimise toward actual revenue, not just clicks.

Set a target ROAS

Once you have 30+ conversions in 30 days, switch from Maximise Clicks to Target ROAS bidding. Set your target at your current ROAS minus 20% — give the algorithm room to learn before tightening.

Exclude converting customers from prospecting

Use your GA4 "All Purchasers" audience to exclude recent buyers from acquisition campaigns. Don't pay to acquire someone you already have.

Common Tracking Mistakes That Cost You Money

Recognise these — they're everywhere.

No UTM parameters on emails and social posts

If you don't tag your links, GA4 classifies the traffic as Direct. You'll never know which emails or social posts are driving revenue. Fix: Always use UTMs on all outbound links. Use a UTM builder spreadsheet.

GA4 and Shopify counting different revenue figures

Usually caused by payment gateways (Afterpay, Zip, PayPal) breaking the thank-you page tracking. Fix: Set up server-side purchase event tracking via Shopify's native GA4 integration or Google Tag Manager.

Counting internal staff traffic

If your team browses the store without IP exclusions, they inflate your session count and deflate your conversion rate. Fix: Add your office IP to the internal traffic filter in GA4 Admin.

Looking at sessions instead of revenue by channel

Sessions tell you someone visited. Revenue tells you someone spent money. Build your reports around revenue and conversion — not volume metrics that feel good but don't connect to income.

Not checking Search Console for indexing errors

Pages not indexed by Google won't appear in search results. Check Search Console → Coverage weekly. Fixing a single indexing error on a high-value page can recover significant organic traffic.

Changing campaigns before waiting for statistical significance

Pausing an ad after 3 days because it has zero conversions is premature. Most B2C purchase cycles are 3–14 days. Give campaigns at least 30 conversions or 30 days before drawing conclusions.

Analytics Audit Checklist

Work through this with your current setup.

GA4 Setup

- ☐ GA4 property exists and is connected to your website
- ☐ Purchase event is firing with correct revenue and transaction ID
- ☐ Internal traffic is excluded from reports
- ☐ GA4 is linked to Google Search Console
- ☐ GA4 is linked to Google Ads (if running ads)

Shopify + GA4 Alignment

- ☐ GA4 revenue within 5% of Shopify revenue for last 30 days
- ☐ Checkout events (begin_checkout, add_payment_info) are tracking
- ☐ Payment gateway redirects are not breaking the purchase event
- ☐ Product view and add_to_cart events are present in Realtime

Reporting

- ☐ Revenue by Channel report saved in GA4 Explore
- ☐ Checkout Funnel visualisation set up in GA4
- ☐ Weekly review routine in place (or scheduled)
- ☐ Shopify report for returning customer rate accessible

Google Ads (if applicable)

- ☐ Auto-tagging enabled in Google Ads
- ☐ Purchase conversion imported from GA4
- ☐ Purchaser audience excluded from prospecting campaigns
- ☐ ROAS reported by campaign, not just overall

WANT CLEAN DATA – FAST?

Your Analytics, Fixed Properly.

Ignition Agency offers a GA4 + Shopify analytics audit as part of our AI Readiness Assessment. We'll identify what's broken, fix the critical issues, and set you up with the five reports that actually matter.

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